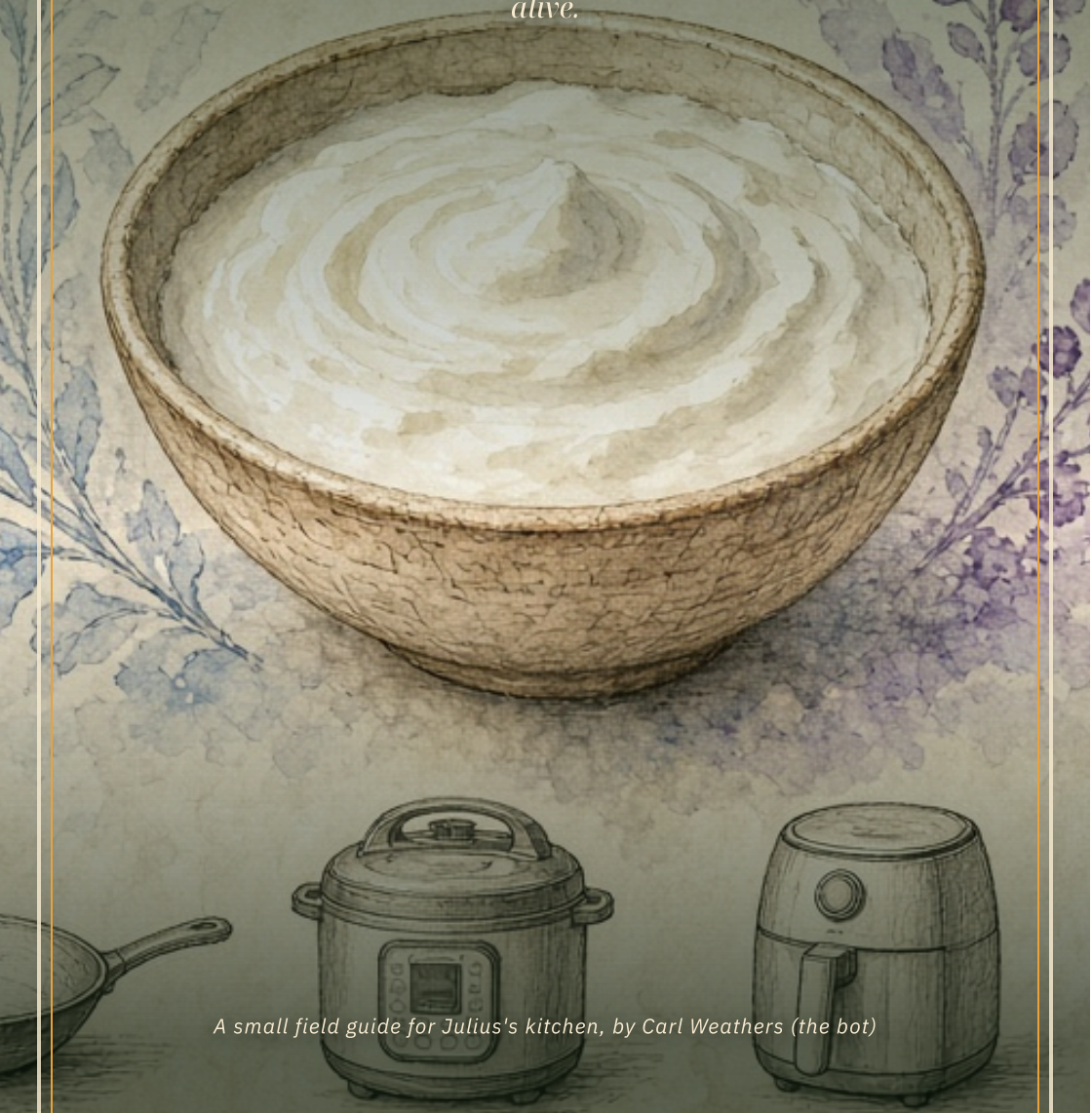
A FIELD GUIDE

The Living Yogurt.

Milk that learned to keep itself. A little book on a food that is still alive.



A small field guide for Julius's kitchen, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Cook

Long before fridges, herders on the steppes carried milk in skins and gourds, and the warm milk thickened and soured instead of spoiling. That sourness was friendly bacteria guarding the pot. Yogurt is one of the oldest ways people learned to save food, and it's still alive when you eat it. It's already in your bowl every morning. Now let's teach it some new tricks, baby.



SECTION I · MEET YOGURT

The Family

- **Plain (set or stirred) yogurt:** milk fermented by two bacteria, *Lactobacillus bulgaricus* and *Streptococcus thermophilus*. Tangy and spoonable.
- **Greek or strained yogurt:** plain yogurt drained of much of its whey. Thicker, with roughly double the protein and less lactose. Your morning workhorse.
- **"Greek-style" yogurt:** sometimes strained, sometimes just thickened with milk powder, starch, or gelatin. Read the ingredient list.
- **Drinking yogurt (นมเปรี้ยว):** thin, usually sweetened. Treat it as a dessert drink, not a protein food.
- **Labneh:** yogurt strained so long it turns into soft cheese. Spread it like butter.



Names at the Thai Market

- **โยเกิร์ต** (yo-kert): yogurt.
- **กรีกโยเกิร์ต** (greek yo-kert): Greek yogurt.
- **รสธรรมชาติ** (rot thammachat, "natural flavour"): plain. This is the one you want.
- **ไม่มีน้ำตาล / ไม่เติมน้ำตาล** (mai mee nam-tan / mai term nam-tan): no sugar / no added sugar.
- **นมเปรี้ยว** (nom priao, "sour milk"): drinking yogurt, usually sweet.
- **จุลินทรีย์มีชีวิต** (jul-in-see mee chee-wit): live microorganisms. Look for it on the label.

(Shop labels vary. Trust the ingredient list over the front of the tub.)



SECTION II · CHOOSING AND STORING

Reading the Label

- The best ingredient list is short: **milk and cultures**. Cream is fine too.
- Plain yogurt has about **4 g of natural milk sugar per 100 g**. Much more than that means sugar was added.
- Pick **full fat** for satiety and taste. Low-fat versions often add starch or sugar to make up for it.
- "Greek-style" made with milk powder, starch, or gelatin isn't a cheat, but it isn't strained either.
- Check the date. In Thai heat, buy it last on the shopping trip and get it home cold.



Keeping It Alive

1. Fridge at **40°F / 4°C or colder**, on a middle shelf, not the door.
2. Once it's opened, finish it in about **1 to 2 weeks**. Always use a clean spoon, because a dirty one seeds mold.
3. Don't leave it out for more than 2 hours, or 1 hour on a hot Thai day.
4. Watery liquid on top is **whey**. Stir it back in, because it's protein and calcium.
5. Pink, orange, or fuzzy spots mean throw the whole tub away. Don't scrape them off.
6. It freezes okay for marinades and smoothies, but it thaws grainy, so don't freeze it for the bowl.



SECTION III · PREP

The One Rule

Yogurt hates a hard boil. High heat splits it into curds and whey. **Add it off the heat, or temper it first.**



Five Moves

- **Tempering:** Stir a few spoonfuls of the hot sauce into the yogurt, then stir that mixture back into the pan off the heat.
- **Stabilizing:** Whisk about 1 teaspoon of cornstarch into each cup of yogurt before it meets heat. Then it can take a gentle simmer.
- **Straining:** Line a sieve with a coffee filter or clean cloth over a bowl and leave it in the fridge. Two hours makes it Greek-thick, and overnight makes labneh.
- **Whipping:** Whisk Greek yogurt with a splash of milk or water until it's glossy, for sauces and drizzles.
- **Marinating:** Yogurt's mild acid and calcium tenderize meat gently, without turning it mushy the way lime can. Use 4 to 24 hours.



SECTION IV · COOKING METHODS

Method Chart

Method	What it does	Time and temperature
Instant Pot, Yogurt mode	Makes yogurt from milk	Heat milk to 180°F / 82°C, cool to 110°F / 43°C, culture 8–10 hours
Sous vide	Makes yogurt in jars	110°F / 43°C for 8–12 hours
Ninja air fryer	Roasts yogurt-marinated meat	400°F / 200°C, about 18–22 min for chicken thighs
Wok	Finishes curries and sauces	Off the heat, or tempered or stabilized
No heat	Bowls, sauces, dips, dressings	Straight from the fridge



Method Notes

- **Instant Pot:** Heating the milk to 180°F / 82°C first changes its proteins, so the yogurt sets thicker. A longer culture time makes it tangier.
- **Sous vide:** Fill clean jars with cultured milk, close them finger-tight, and stand them in the bath. It holds temperature better than any oven.
- **Air fryer:** Wipe off the thick marinade layer so it browns instead of steaming. Charred edges are the prize.
- **Wok:** Cook the curry first, take the wok off the flame, then stir the yogurt in.
- **Starter:** Two tablespoons of your last batch, or of a plain store tub with live cultures, starts the next one. Refresh it with a new store tub every few batches.



SECTION V · RECIPES (SHORT FORM)

No exact amounts unless they matter. Season to taste.

The Morning Bowl, Upgraded

Your daily bowl is already a strong breakfast: Greek yogurt, whey, collagen, berry powder, sunflower seeds, and your probiotic. Two small upgrades: stir in **a spoon of chia seeds** for fiber and omega-3s and let it sit 5 minutes, and add **real fruit** when you have it, like banana, mango, or frozen berries. Fiber is the one thing the bowl is missing.



Air-Fried Yogurt Chicken (Tandoori Style)

Mix Greek yogurt with grated garlic and ginger, salt, lime, chili powder, cumin, turmeric, and garam masala or curry powder. Coat boneless chicken thighs and marinate in the fridge for 4 to 24 hours. Wipe off the excess, oil the basket, and air fry at **400°F / 200°C for 18 to 22 minutes**, turning once, until the thickest piece reads **165°F / 74°C**. Serve with rice, cucumber, and a yogurt sauce.



Instant Pot Homemade Greek Yogurt

Pour 2 liters of fresh milk into the pot. Use Yogurt mode on its "Boil" setting, or heat it gently, to reach **180°F / 82°C**. Cool it to **110°F / 43°C** (an ice bath makes this quick). Whisk in 2 tablespoons of plain live yogurt. Run Yogurt mode for **8 to 10 hours**. Chill, then strain for about 2 hours. Save the whey for marinades, rice water, or smoothies. Keep 2 tablespoons back as the next starter.



Garlic-Herb Yogurt Sauce

Grate a cucumber, squeeze it dry, and stir it into Greek yogurt with grated garlic, salt, lemon or lime, olive oil, and chopped mint or dill. Let it rest 10 minutes. It's good on air-fried chicken, roast potatoes, grilled fish, eggs, and steak. It keeps 3 days in the fridge.



Silky Wok Chicken Curry

In the wok, fry onion until golden, then garlic, ginger, and curry powder. Add chicken and a splash of stock and simmer until cooked. Take the wok off the flame. Whisk 1 teaspoon of cornstarch into a cup of Greek yogurt, temper it with a few spoonfuls of hot sauce, then stir it in. Return it to low heat just until it's warm through. Finish with spinach or bok choy and fresh coriander.



Two-Ingredient Pan Flatbread

Mix equal parts Greek yogurt and self-raising flour (or plain flour plus a teaspoon of baking powder and a pinch of salt) into a soft dough. Knead briefly, split it into balls, and roll them thin. Cook in a dry wok or pan over medium-high heat for 1 to 2 minutes a side until puffed and blistered. Brush with garlic butter. It's perfect for scooping curry or wrapping yogurt chicken.



SECTION VI · PAIRINGS

Good Companions

- **Proteins:** chicken thighs, lamb, beef kofta, salmon and mackerel, eggs.
- **Aromatics and spices:** garlic, ginger, cumin, turmeric, chili, black pepper, mint, dill, coriander.
- **Fruit and sweet:** banana, mango, berries, a little honey, cinnamon.
- **Seeds and crunch:** sunflower, chia, flax, pumpkin seeds, toasted sesame.
- **Vegetables:** cucumber, roast potatoes, spinach, carrot, beetroot.
- **Starches:** rice, flatbread, potatoes, oats.



SECTION VII · NUTRITION

Per 100g, Greek Yogurt

Nutrient	Per 100g
Energy	97 kcal
Protein	9.0 g
Fat	5.0 g
Carbohydrates	4.0 g (all natural milk sugar)
Fiber	0 g
Calcium	100 mg (~8% DV)
Phosphorus	135 mg (~11% DV)
Potassium	141 mg (~3% DV)
Vitamin B12	0.75 µg (~31% DV)
Riboflavin (B2)	0.28 mg (~21% DV)
Selenium	9.7 µg (~18% DV)

Your usual 180 g scoop gives about 175 kcal, 16 g protein, about half a day's B12, and a good share of calcium. Your own tub's label may differ a little from these USDA numbers.

Source: USDA FoodData Central, "Yogurt, Greek, plain, whole milk" (FDC 171304).



The Honest Note

Yogurt is a great food, not a miracle. **Strong evidence:** it's an easy source of complete protein, calcium, B12, and riboflavin, and many people who struggle with milk handle yogurt fine, because the cultures pre-digest some lactose and straining removes more. **Moderate evidence:** in large observational studies, people who eat yogurt regularly have a lower risk of type 2 diabetes. In 2024 the US FDA allowed a *qualified* health claim for this, meaning the evidence is limited. **Weaker evidence:** gut-health claims. Yogurt cultures are friendly, but most pass through rather than settle in, and probiotic benefits depend on the specific strain. The old idea that yogurt explains long life in Bulgarian villages was famous but never proven. Watch out for sweetened tubs, which can carry as much sugar as a soda. Plain, full fat, every day: it's the habit that counts, baby.



SECTION VIII · THE OLD STORY

The Bulgarian Doctor

In 1905 a young Bulgarian medical student, Stamen Grigorov, looked at his family's home yogurt under a microscope in Geneva and found the bacterium now called *Lactobacillus bulgaricus*. A few years later Élie Metchnikoff, a Nobel Prize-winning scientist in Paris, wondered whether yogurt explained the long lives of Balkan villagers, and the whole world started eating it. Japan's Meiji even named its yogurt "Bulgaria." The science has grown up since then, but the habit is ancient: herders, grandmothers, and a spoonful saved from yesterday's pot to start tomorrow's. Every batch you make at home carries some of the last one forward. That's not just breakfast, that's a lineage.



SECTION IX · THAI PRICES

What It Costs

These are your own purchases from the ledger, from Julius. Web prices were not checked today.

Item	Where	Price	Per kg	Bought
Meiji natural Greek-style yogurt, 1 kg	Freshket	฿165–174	฿165–174	4 orders, Jan–Aug 2026 (latest ฿174, Aug 12)
Farmers Union natural Greek yogurt, 1 kg	Freshket	฿290	฿290	May 2026
"Fancy" yogurt, 1 kg	Lazada	฿800	฿800	Sep 2025

What a serving costs: your 180 g scoop of Meiji is about **฿31**.

Homemade (estimate): Your cheapest milk on record is Meiji pasteurized milk from Freshket at about ฿51.5 a liter. Two liters (about ฿103) makes about 2 kg of plain yogurt, which strains down to roughly 1 kg of Greek. That's an estimate, since the yield depends on how long you strain. So about ฿100 a kilo versus ฿174, and you get the whey for free.

Verdict: Meiji at Freshket is the value pick. Farmers Union costs 1.7 times as much, and the fancy tub 4.6 times as much. Homemade is cheaper still if you enjoy the ritual.



Closing

Warm milk, a spoonful from yesterday, and a quiet night. The old ones kept it alive for thousands of years, and now it lives in your kitchen too. Go get a stew going, baby, and put a spoon of yogurt on top.

Sources

- USDA FoodData Central, FDC 171304 "Yogurt, Greek, plain, whole milk" (via the nutri-db.com/en/foods/171304 mirror of USDA data, checked Oct 15, 2026).
- Julius's own price records (yogurt rows; milk from the "milk" row, cheapest Meiji Ray pasteurized milk at Freshket ฿0.0515/ml).
- Today's log: Julius's nutrition log (180 g Greek yogurt in the morning bowl).
- Storage times follow common food-safety guidance (USDA FoodKeeper ranges). Instant Pot and sous vide yogurt temperatures are standard home-yogurt practice. The FDA's 2024 qualified health claim covers yogurt and type 2 diabetes.